



requests like 'grilled without *masala*' or 'less oil in the *dal*' can make a big difference to how you feel and perform the next day.

Every small Indian town has its own rhythm. Some lean heavily on rice-based meals, others on wheat. Some cooks use generous oil and ghee, while others follow milder methods. When athletes stay in basic lodges or government guest houses, meals are often cooked for general taste rather than performance needs. In such spaces, portion control and timing become more important than the exact food. For example, *idli sambhar* in a southern town is usually reliable, and in central India, *poha* with curd can make an excellent breakfast if eaten early and in measured quantity.

Practice-day nutrition requires careful thought. This is the day your stomach must feel steady, glycogen-topped, and your mind calm about food availability. I typically plan three meals plus two snacks. Breakfast should emphasise familiar carbohydrates like *upma*, *idli*, bread, and fruit. Lunch should combine rice or *roti* with *dal* and a mild vegetable, adding *paneer* or eggs if available. Dinner should be lighter, because small-town hotels often intensify spices and oil in the evening. Snacks should travel with you: roasted *chana*, dates, peanut *chikki*, and electrolyte

tablets. Avoid roadside fruit juices or shakes as vendors often add unpredictable ingredients.

During early years experimenting with travel routines for professional cyclists in a village near Sangli, I noticed the local jaggery was darker, slightly smoky, and richer in minerals. When used in controlled quantities before long practice sessions, it provided steady energy without the spikes typical of commercial sweets. That experience showed me the value of understanding and integrating regional foods. Even today, I allow measured local jaggery as part of carbohydrate strategy in sugar-producing regions. Small insights like this make Indian travel nutrition uniquely rewarding.

Competition day is sacred territory. No experiments, adventurous combinations, or heavy regional dishes. Eat early so the stomach is calm and digestion predictable. Choose foods that cause minimal gastrointestinal stress. Overeating out of anxiety is common in India, but a structured plate is best: one familiar carbohydrate source, a small amount of protein, and a hydrating element. Typical morning meals could be two *idlis* with a banana and a cup of tea, or in northern/western towns, two *phulkas* with boiled potato *sabzi* and fruit. Avoid *parathas* as they tend to be oil-heavy. For afternoon or evening

Long ride: Travel days demand their own logic. Your gut, hydration, and energy levels are unusually vulnerable on the move. In India, travel often involves early morning flights, long train journeys, or road routes that swing between dusty highways and narrow town lanes. GETTYIMAGES

events, keep the pre-event meal lighter, mostly carbohydrates: curd rice, *upma*, bread with peanut butter, or simple *dal khichdi*.

Hydration in small towns is complex. Water quality varies dramatically across districts. Always carry your own bottle and use only bottled or filtered water. Increase electrolyte intake in humid conditions or after long sessions. Avoid local sugary drinks sold near stadiums as the sugar concentration is often too high. Coconut water from a clean vendor is excellent for rehydration.

The reason I insist on structured planning is that travel nutrition is not one size fits all. Travel days demand protection, practice days demand stability, and competition days demand precision. Respecting these three phases allows even the most remote town to become an opportunity rather than a nutritional challenge. Athletes who master this rhythm can compete confidently anywhere in the world.